

weekend

wkcd

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SLEEPLESS IN KAVVAYI
In this town in Kerala, we stay up to witness the Kaliyattam festival and tell you how to savour the experience **P5**



Thousands of stranded travellers remain hopeful. GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK

As regional tensions shut airspace and cancel flights across West Asia, first-hand accounts from Dubai, Doha and Jordan show how residents, volunteers and diaspora networks are stepping in to support stranded travellers

When the

sky changes

Barry Rodgers
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There are moments when geopolitics feels like an abstraction, and then there are weeks like this one, when it arrives in the most ordinary of places: departures board at an airport, WhatsApp calls from worried parents, and the uneasy silence of the runway.

The latest tremor began with the joint American and Israeli military strikes on Iranian targets in late February. In the days that followed, the geography of the conflict widened: missiles were intercepted over multiple Gulf Cooperation Council states, a drone strike sparked a fire near the US Consulate in Dubai, and governments across the region moved quickly to close or restrict airspace as a precaution.

For the United Arab Emirates, the disruption was felt first in the sky. Dubai International Airport, normally one of the busiest crossroads of global aviation, saw hundreds of flights get cancelled, leaving passengers stranded.

In Dubai's Jumeirah neighbourhood, Anirudh Nair, a 39-year-old fintech risk analyst originally from Kochi, first sensed that something unusual was unfolding not through headlines but through the skyline. From the balcony of his apartment on the evening of February 28, he watched streaks of light cutting across the horizon.

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pick of the week



Wheels of change

The silver jubilee edition of Indian Oil Corporation's Duchess All Women Car Rally 2026 invites Chennai's women to take the wheel across a 50km clue-led drive. Themed World Of Women...

Over The Years!, the rally flags off on March 8 at 8am from Savera Hotel, Mylapore. The Duchess Club expects more than 100 cars and will offer prizes to the winners. Entry ₹2,000 per car (four participants; lunch included). Registrations: 9841288631/9710947355.



In good faith

This Ramzan, feast on an Iftar buffet featuring dishes that are Ramzan favourites and have rich West Asian influences, at The Westin Chennai Velachery's Seasonal Tastes in Chennai. Expect

haleem, Arabic mezze, nalli nihari, Ambur chicken biryani, sheer khurma, kunafa, gulkand jamun and live grilled kebabs. On till March 19, 6pm onwards; starting at ₹2,550 per person. Reservations 8939892056.



Pocket-size art

The original, certified artworks by folk and contemporary masters like Venkat Raman Singh Shyam, Jogen Chowdhury, Ruchi Bakshi Sharma, Zainab Tambawalla and Tushar

Tanwar will be on display and sale at The Folly, Amethyst, till March 8, 7pm. Presented by Srila Chatterjee, the artworks range from thangka and pichwai to sohrari, with hand-pulled limited edition prints, and are priced above ₹3,000.



Design theory

On Woman's Day, Jimmy Choo is exploring a future feminine narrative through Les Fleurs and The Rules of Engagement 2026 Bridal collections. Highlights

include bar holdall, micro bon bon, Mimmi slingback 50, Sacora, embellished statement sandals with 1,969 pearl details, iconic Faiz pumps with lace details and ivory satin pumps Azia 95 finished with approximately 5,453 stones. ₹1.2 lakh upwards; row.jimmychoo.com

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An older millennial acquaintance, who considers himself fiscally cautious, gainfully employed, and chronically single, confessed to keeping a mental ledger of his dating life. Each evening out costs him between ₹6,000 and ₹7,000. With three to four such outings a month, he is spending close to ₹25,000 on dates and returning home, more often than not, with the distinct sense that he might have preferred a book and an early night. "This," he told me, "is my economic reckoning."

On paper, of course, none of this should feel particularly alarming. India's retail inflation in early 2026 stands at 2.75% year-on-year, well within the Reserve Bank of India's 2-6% tolerance band, according to Government Consumer Price Index (CPI) data released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. Food inflation is hovering just above 2%. The macroeconomic story is one of stability, even restraint. Groceries are not spiralling, fuel prices are not detonating, and yet dating in an Indian metro exists in a microclimate where the CPI feels like a distant abstraction. The CPI basket does not account for ₹1,500 cocktails, the 5% GST levied on most standalone restaurant bills, the 18% that may apply in certain hotel establishments, or the State excise duties that keep alcohol outside the GST framework altogether and firmly in its own expensive republic.

Alcohol, the quintessential date-night indulgence – even as Gen Z experiments with sober-curious evenings and artisanal mocktails – remains the millennial-coping mechanism of choice, particularly when the conversation falters. A 37-year-old marketing consultant put it plainly: "If the date is boring, at least let the drink be strong. But now the drink is weak, and the bill is strong." She still pregames,



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

THE NAKED TRUTH

Love on a dime

In India's steady 2026 economy, it isn't groceries but date nights that feel expensive, and singles are adjusting accordingly

unapologetically. "One gin at home, one cocktail outside. I'm not paying ₹1,500 for diluted rubbish most bars serve. I'll be

lucky if I get 60ml of alcohol despite the tall claims." Between excise duties, GST on food, service charges that hover near

10%, and the rising operational costs restaurants quietly pass on, a casual dinner for two can potentially cross ₹4,000 before uttering the word dessert.

Who's getting the bill? What is emerging, then, is not miserliness but a kind of romantic recalibration. Frugal dating, as several people described it to me, is less about austerity and more about value. A 29-year-old start-up founder has moved his first dates from bars to bookstores, where the stakes are lower. "You learn more about someone by which shelf they linger at," he said, with the serenity of someone who has abandoned the tyranny of reservations. "Worst case, I leave with a book. Best case, I leave with both."

A Gen Z consultant in Bengaluru has her own rules, shaped as much by ideology as by budget. "We split everything. Even the auto ride," she said. "I don't want romance built on financial resentment." For her, coffee is the perfect first-date

instrument: a ₹300 cappuccino that buys 45 minutes of assessment. "If it's bad, I've only lost caffeine."

Meanwhile, a 38-year-old investment banker confessed that he has become adept at recognising what he calls the lifestyle audit. "If she suggests omakase on a Tuesday, I know I'm being stress-tested," he laughed, without bitterness. He doesn't necessarily object to paying, but he now counter-suggests mid-range restaurants with what he describes as "good conversation acoustics," places where neither the music nor the menu overwhelms the point of the evening.

Then there are the domestic realists, who have dispensed with the theatre of dining out altogether. A 32-year-old architect has begun inviting dates home, not recklessly but deliberately. "We cook together. Pasta is neutral territory. If he can chop garlic and talk about his childhood without mansplaining olive oil, we're good." They end the evening with a walk, partly to soften the intimacy and partly because, as she put it, "the walk costs nothing and tells you everything."

Even those who adore a well-made drink are selective about when to indulge. A 40-year-old creative director told me she reserves craft bars for celebrations. "Not compatibility testing. I'm not investing ₹8,000 to find out you call yourself a 'sapiosexual'."

Perhaps this is the quiet thesis of dating in 2026. As one 36-year-old entrepreneur told me, with a shrug that suggested both fatigue and wisdom, "I don't mind paying. I mind paying for mediocrity."

It's safe to say dating is not dying but being audited. And if someone can hold your attention without a ₹1,500 cocktail buffering the silence, that may be the most persuasive metric of all.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



Wicked with a wink

Director John Stefaniuk on friendship, spectacle, cancel culture, and why this reimagined *Wicked* speaks directly to today's audience

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The Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre has made something of a habit of importing spectacle. After hosting crowd-pullers like *The Sound of Music*, *The Phantom of the Opera* and *The Nutcracker*, it now welcomes its ninth international showcase: *Wicked*, which runs from March 12-29. And not just any *Wicked*, but an entirely new production that carries the same beloved score and script while reimagining the direction, choreography and design for a fresh generation. Globally, *Wicked* has drawn more than 65 million people across 130 cities in 16 countries. Its songs – "Defying Gravity", "Popular", "For Good" – have become cultural shorthand for ambition, friendship and the kind of heartbreak that still

leaves you standing. The story, based on *Wicked*, with music and lyrics by Stephen Schwartz and a book by Winnie Holzman, takes us back to Oz long before Dorothy's neat pigtails and ruby slippers. It asks a far more unsettling question: who decided one woman was wicked and the other good?

At the helm of this new staging is director John Stefaniuk, who approaches the material with a keen awareness that the world has shifted since the show first opened over two decades ago. He says, "For me, the greatest shift in the last 20 years has been the introduction of social media. Glinda is truly the first Ozian social influencer, spreading her thoughts through bubbles across the land," John explains.



"Elphaba, on the other hand, is a victim of cancel culture, shouldering the burden of being different and then cancelled from speaking the truth."

To bring those themes of identity, prejudice and public shaming to life, John keeps the rehearsal room stripped back at first. "I always begin every rehearsal process sitting at a table where we don't rely on the set or costumes or movement, we only rely on the text and understanding what and why we say every word on the page," he says.

That truth is most tenderly felt in the evolving friendship between Elphaba and Glinda, played here by Rebekah Lowings and Eve Shanu-Wilson. Their

(Left) The cast of *Wicked*; and, John Stefaniuk. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

on-stage rivalry softens into something deeper and far more enduring, and John admits that watching their off-stage camaraderie grow was half the magic.

Visually, John imagines Oz as two worlds running in parallel: the glossy public façade and the unsettling private machinery beneath. "When looking at the Emerald City at first glance, it is a funfair much like Lunar Park or Coney Island from the turn of the century," he says. "On closer examination, though, we see it is nothing more than cages capturing and enslaving its inhabitants and punishing those who speak out against it."

It is this shift in perspective that blurs the neat line between good and evil. The Wizard's grandeur begins to look suspiciously like spin, and Elphaba's so-called wickedness feels closer to moral courage.

For Indian audiences encountering *Wicked* live in Mumbai for the first time, John believes there is a natural bridge. "India has always had such global recognition for its Bollywood films," he says, noting the shared love of music-driven storytelling. "In the same way, it blends the spectacle and heart in the same exciting and joyous way!"

And spectacle there is, from soaring witches to a tornado that seems to sweep through the auditorium itself, supported by a company of over 100 performers, crew and orchestra members, hundreds of costumes and a design team that treats Oz as both playground and warning sign.

And perhaps that is why *Wicked* endures.

Beneath the emerald sheen and gravity-defying theatrics lies a story about being misunderstood, about standing up for oneself, and about friendships that change the course of your life.

Tickets start from ₹2,000; available on nmacc.com or bookmyshow.com

Tapping into the primal

The fourth edition of the Mahindra Percussion Festival 2026 brings The Pulse Within to Bengaluru



Mahesh Kale is one of the artists who will be performing at the Mahindra Percussion Festival 2026

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Without rhythm, melody would float off without direction. Percussion brings tempo, pulse, and groove; it is the structural backbone of music," says VG Jairam, festival director, Mahindra Percussion Festival.

Talking about the upcoming Mahindra Percussion Festival 2026, he adds, "Percussion itself as a form of expression lies at the heart of music. It has been the heartbeat of music from ancient tribal gatherings to modern day concerts. Rhythm is humanity's most primal and powerful form of expression." Titled, The Pulse Within, the festival will be held on March 7 and 8.

Jairam mentions vocalist Mahesh Kale who will be presenting Yatra, "the spiritual rhythmic sounds of India and how he is exploring an expression of infinity through rhythm".

One of the highlights of the festival will be a collaboration between mridangist Umayalpuram K Sivaraman, tabla artiste Ishaan Ghosh and drummer Shravan Samsi, titled Nada Pravaham - Circle of Sound. "If you look at Indian classical music – whether it is the tabla, ghatam or any other instrument that aids in the rhythmic cycle or *taal* – percussion is not purely decorative, but rather the key architecture of a piece," says



Jairam. The festival will see the presence of unusual instruments such as the parai. "Though this art form is associated with funerals in South India today, there is a lot of history behind it which has largely been forgotten. The overall objective of the festival has always been to make percussion more accessible and listener-friendly to the younger generation, so they understand its value and see how deeply rooted it is in our culture."

Another important segment of the festival is Women Who Drum, which will feature musicians Swarupa Ananth, Charu Hariharan, Nush Lewis, Hamta Baghi, and Shalini Mohan. Grammy nominee Bickram Ghosh will be presenting Drums of the East at the festival.

The Pulse Within, by Mahindra Percussion Festival 2026 in association with The Hindu, will take place on March 7 and 8, 2026, at the Prestige Centre for Performing Arts, Konankunte, Bengaluru from 5pm. Schedule of events and tickets starting from ₹1,000 available on BookMyShow

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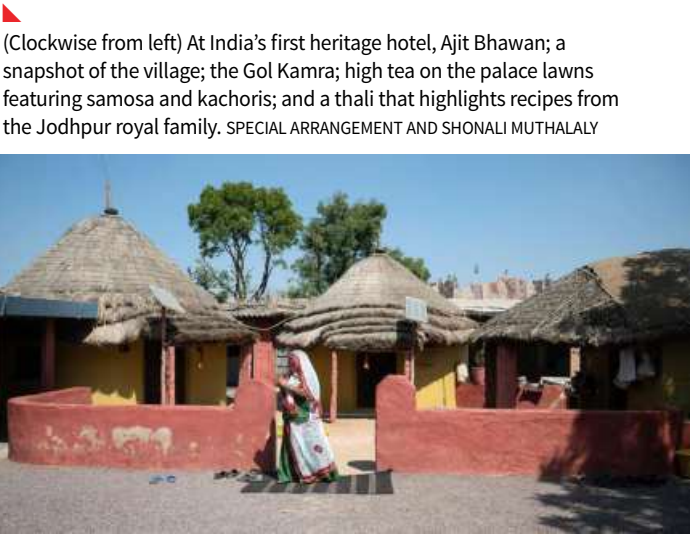


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who are still deeply involved with the hotel. “They check the rooms, approve the fabric and linen. Rani Usha Devi oversees the gardens...” Raj Ratnu, front office manager, nods: “They know all of us, and meet our families as well as locals during the annual Holi celebrations.” Pair this loyalty with the drive of Ajit Bhawan’s current generation, Raghavendra Rathore (the popular fashion designer) and Suryaveer Singh, and the result is a lovingly tended, unapologetically whimsical getaway: we eat samosas for high tea under a canopy in the garden one day, supervised by the friendly palace cat, and nibble on kachoris the next, in the royal Gol Kamra shimmering with chandeliers and crystal



Ajit Bhawan is breaking away from the clichés by reviving and updating lost royal recipes for a modern audience, learning from the past while building for the future

The night I dug up dinner

At Ajit Bhawan, chefs revive the Jodhpur royal family’s lost recipes by slow cooking meat in a pit, highlighting local produce and simple flavours

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In the moonlit gardens of a palace, I stand in a cabbage patch with a chef and a hoe. Chef Bikram Chandra Khadka cuts through the warm earth, careful to keep his white apron pristine. There is a clang. We kneel and lift out a steamy bundle, wrapped in sackcloth and bound with wire. A little deeper, we unearth a sealed *handi*. The seductive scent of caramelised meat, threaded with damp earth and smoke, wraps around us. Dinner is served. I am at Ajit Bhawan, built in 1927 as the residence of

Maharaj Dhiraj Sir Ajit Singh, the younger brother of Maharaja Umaid Singh of Jodhpur. In the late 1970s, part of it was opened to guests by the family, introducing the romance of royal Rajasthan to the world. Heritage hotels across Rajasthan tend to lean heavily on history, glamour and laal maas. Ajit Bhawan is breaking away from the clichés by reviving lost royal recipes for a modern audience, learning from the past while building for the future. My first lunch of jungli maas at the hotel is deeply satisfying. Made with lean, flavour-dense mutton from Narlai village, where herds roam freely and feed off the arid grasslands, it stays true to the simple recipe

that originated from royal hunts: just ghee, salt, garlic and local brick-red Mathania chillies, famed for their complex, smoky heat. “Now, they eat light food at the palace, things like salads and soups,” smiles Chef Bikram. But even as the palace kitchens have quietened, the hotel is becoming a testing ground for extravagant menus that keep the past alive. After all, this is a family that created what is arguably India’s first heritage hotel. “In the early days, the family would take care of each guest personally, from taking bookings to supervising the rooms. Maharaj Swaroop Singh ji would say every guest is an ambassador,” says Magan Kanwar, assistant front office

manager, as she checks me in and hands me my ornate brass room key. She adds, “He started the Bishnoi village safaris. He would drive the jeep and take visitors to show them the culture of Rajasthan.” Suraj Panwar, the reservations and revenue manager, explains how the palace, built in 1927, is still home to the royals, who occupy a section of the sprawling six-acre estate. Like the rest of the staff – some of whom have worked at the property for three decades – he talks fondly of the family,

warrior cooks on hunts. “It was done with a local breed of hen that is harder to catch,” says Chef Bikram, adding with a laugh, “As it browns, we just add water. Rajasthani water has a high sodium content, it is like stock.” There is also a slow-cooked layered rice, fragrant with saffron and crunchy with nuts, cooked in heavy sealed pots and sometimes slow-baked underground. Earlier in the day, we explored the Blue City’s century-old havelis, picking our way through garbage and open sewers to admire the intricate jaali work and the beautiful hues of blue. In between, I tried all the street food legends: makhania lassi at Mishrilal Hotel that was overwhelmingly sweet, plump gulab jamuns that were rather mellow and huge kachoris fried in ghee. At a time when food revels in theatrics, what makes Ajit Bhawan’s cooking so alluring is restraint. I cannot put down their version of makhania lassi, served in small mud cups: it’s tangy with an almost elusive whisper of saffron. In keeping with tradition, Nitin had taken us to the Bishnoi village in the morning, where Tulsi Ram, who learned all his English on the *BBC*, smiled and declared, “I’m going to spread my dreams beneath your feet,” before rolling out his handmade dhurries and explaining how each one takes a month to make. In the evening, as dinner gives way to late-night tequila shots accompanied by slices of oranges topped with caramelised sugar and cinnamon, Nitin tells us how he once helped the team light 1,500 diyas at the Rawla Narlai stepwell, so guests could eat dinner in their flickering light. I lean back and look at the stars, under gloriously tangled bougainvillea bushes aflame with flowers. A weekend revelling in the extravagance of a palace is undeniably a privilege. But this glimpse of royal life also reveals that real luxury lies in being surrounded by a loyal community, generous with their time and talent. The writer was in Jodhpur on invitation from Ajit Bhawan.

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“Dubai’s night sky is usually very predictable,” he said. “You see planes lining up for landing, construction cranes blinking red across the skyline. That night, the lights were moving differently.” Messages quickly began circulating in neighbourhood WhatsApp groups suggesting that air-defence systems had intercepted drones or missiles somewhere over the Gulf. The following morning, he opened the Emirates app to confirm the flight he had booked to Kochi for a family function: “It had simply disappeared from the schedule.” Like many travellers that day, he spent hours trying to reach airline helplines, only to encounter automated messages about unusually high call volumes. Eventually, the airline issued a refund for the cancelled ticket, though securing another seat proved difficult as passengers across the region began trying to rearrange their journeys simultaneously. “At some point you stop calling and just keep refreshing the app,” he said. “You hope something opens up.” Anirudh is postponing any plans of visiting India.

Finding hope Several hundred kilometres away, Priyanka Sharma was navigating a similar disruption. A pharmaceutical sales manager from Pune, she had travelled to Doha for meetings tied to a healthcare distribution project her company was negotiating with a regional partner. The plan had included two days of meetings, then a flight back to Mumbai. The meetings turned out to be the least complicated part of the trip. “People started checking their phones as soon as the news about the strikes began circulating,” she



When the sky changes

said. “At first, everything still looked normal.” Over the next few hours, departure boards at Hamad International Airport began changing as airlines reassessed routes through regional airspace. Flights were delayed and eventually cancelled, including Priyanka’s return service to India. “The airline told us the ticket would be refunded,” she said. “But that doesn’t mean you can immediately get another seat.” Her employer extended her stay in Doha and arranged accommodation at a nearby hotel. For the next two days, Priyanka tried several alternatives – direct flights, connections through Muscat and even a longer route through Colombo – but seats appeared and vanished from booking apps almost instantly. “You would see a seat available for a few seconds and

then it would disappear,” she said. “It felt like everyone in the Gulf was trying to rebook at the same time.” Priyanka is holding out hope to return to India soon. **Don’t panic** The scale of the Indian presence in the region makes disruptions like these particularly complex. According to estimates cited by Anish Gawande, national spokesperson for the Nationalist Congress Party – Sharadchandra Pawar faction, roughly 3.5 to 4.5 million Indians live in the UAE, while nearly 10 million Indian citizens live across the Gulf region. “The advice right now is simple: stay where you are and avoid unnecessary travel,” Anish said. “People should also stay away from areas around US military or diplomatic establishments.” He emphasised that civilians are not

(From left) Air travellers, who were stranded in Dubai, are greeted upon arrival at Vassil Levski International Airport in Sofia, Bulgaria; an Indian passenger arrives safely on a flight via Dubai; and travellers at an airport. AFP, ANI, AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



the intended targets of the attacks. “These are drone interceptions,” he said. “What people are seeing in some places is debris falling from intercepted drones. These are not targeted strikes on civilian homes or residential areas.” For now, the biggest challenges are logistical rather than

security-related. Travellers whose flights were cancelled are often being accommodated by airlines, though not always consistently. “Some stranded passengers are being put up in hotels by airlines, but many others are having to fend for themselves and pay extremely high prices for accommodation or alternative tickets,” he said. The problem is particularly stressful for travellers stuck mid-journey, especially those who were transiting through West Asia from Europe or North America and suddenly found their connecting flights cancelled. “Refunds alone don’t solve the problem,” he said. “In many cases, they don’t come close to covering the cost of new tickets under current conditions.” **You are safe with us** While travellers across the Gulf were scrambling to rearrange their journeys, events were unfolding somewhat differently in Jordan. Freelance journalist Chandreyi Bandyopadhyay had arrived in the country a few days earlier as part of a press trip organised by Royal Jordanian and the Jordan Tourism Board. On February 28, the group was in Aqaba, Jordan’s southern port city, where the geography of the Red Sea brings several borders unusually close together. Later that evening, however, the sky offered a reminder of how near the wider conflict had drawn. “From our hotel balcony, we could see missiles streaking across the sky toward Israel,” Chandreyi said. “There were no sirens in Aqaba, but seeing those trails made the situation suddenly feel very real.” Soon afterwards, the organisers moved the group back to Amman, the Jordanian capital. Overnight, sirens sounded intermittently across the city and flashes could occasionally be seen in the distance as interceptions took place beyond the surrounding hills. The following

day the group travelled to Jerash, about 60 kilometres North of Amman, where the sound of fighter jets passing overhead could be heard. Chandreyi and the other journalists were staying at a local hotel where accommodation and meals had been arranged as part of the visit. For much of the trip organisers assured them that their scheduled departure on March 2 would proceed normally. The Indian Embassy in Amman contacted Chandreyi and other travellers to ask them to register their presence so officials could track citizens in case assistance became necessary. At one point, when the group appeared anxious about travel plans, organisers suggested a brief detour to one of Amman’s well-known dessert shops. “They told us we needed to relax,” she said. Chandreyi arrived in Mumbai on March 3. **Open doors** Elsewhere in Dubai, another resident had responded to the disruption in her own way. Rhea Mehra, who manages several rental apartments across the country, posted a brief message on Instagram offering temporary accommodation to families stranded by cancelled flights free of cost. “Within a few hours we had more than a thousand messages,” she said. “People were sending screenshots of cancelled tickets and asking if they could stay for a few nights.” Rhea manages roughly 50 apartments across Dubai and prioritised families travelling with children and elderly passengers. About 50 families were eventually able to stay in the apartments while waiting for flights to reopen or alternative routes to become available. “We couldn’t help everyone,” she said, “but we tried to help where we could.”



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More often than not, one is exhausted by just planning a holiday: where to stay, things to do and checking off many other things on the itinerary. If you are looking for the next escape as summer approaches, here is a destination where planning requires just one thing: your arrival.

Goa is not a new destination for holiday-goers, with each part of the State offering something different. For those looking for an easy-going, secluded getaway, Little Palm Grove offers you just that. Nestled 250 metres North of Ashvem Beach, the eco-conscious resort is an extension of the Palm Grove Beach Resort that Eva Agardsdotter and Viraj Harmalkar co-founded in 2009. “Little Palm Grove is for those who want to explore Goa with solitude and privacy on priority,” says Eva of the property that opened its doors in December 2025. The property comprises five mud bungalows: four sea-facing and one garden-view. Each bungalow opens to a verandah with a private plunge pool that overlooks the Arabian Sea.

The idea took root in 2011 when the team constructed a simple bamboo bungalow resort next to the existing Palm Grove Beach Resort. “That was the beginning of Little



Ashvem’s hidden grove

Little Palm Grove in Goa pairs mud architecture, private pools and beachside solitude for an easy summer getaway

Palm Grove. We were looking at renovating it when the pandemic hit and the project went on a pause until 2024,” says Eva, adding that they then refreshed the project and envisioned it as an oasis for guests. “We wanted to create something that was open through the year, blended with Nature, and gave

guests a deeper insight into Goan culture. Hotels here more or less look the same, and we wanted to stand out.”

The result is a thoughtfully designed, intimate property, enveloped in shades of earthy brown and green. Inspired by traditional Goan mud architecture, the



bungalows “remain naturally cool, creating a comfortable indoor environment, perfectly suited to Goa’s tropical landscape,” says architect Pradeep Naik. The walls are finished with a lime coat, making them breathable, and the flooring uses yellow shabad stone from Hyderabad. Each bungalow comes with a comfortable king-size bed, a sofa that converts into an additional bed, and a writing desk. The verandah has a large day bed, perfect to lounge on after a dip in the private pool; and a dining table where breakfast promptly arrives every morning.



Snapshots from the property that offers solitude and Nature in ample measure. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Breakfast comprises a range of offerings: parathas and idlis; several egg preparations, granola bowls, freshly made smoothies, avocado toast and more. For lunch and dinner, guests head to the restaurant at Palm Grove that has sea food offerings, and traditional Goan fare. Highlights include grilled prawns and calamari, avocado pizza, edamame rigatoni, and grandma’s prawn curry. So, what does a slow holiday here look like? Kickstart your morning with a yoga session organised by the property or practise on your own using the yoga mats provided in every room. Next, we suggest heading to the beach for a swim before going back to the bungalow where breakfast (that you order the previous evening) awaits you in the private verandah. Take a stroll, lounge about before heading to the spa where you wish time stands still. I was quite close to booking a ticket

for the masseuse and bringing her home. Don’t worry, I did not so you can get a brilliant massage when you visit.

Post lunch, head to the local market, cafe hop, or take up a pottery session that the team organises in collaboration with local studio, Mati Earth Studio. Nature enthusiasts, can take an evening boat ride into the Chapora river with Beatroute Explorers, to spot mangroves, birds, and mugger crocodiles (if you are lucky).

If you are surprised that there is so much to do in Goa than just pub hop or get a tan, the next time you plan that Goa getaway, you now know where to head.

Little Palm Grove is at Ashvem Beach, Mandrem, Goa. Priced ₹35,000 a night from March to April.

The writer was in Goa at the invitation of Little Palm Grove

The American-Italian restaurant chain, operated by Gourmet Investments in India, opens in Gurugram on April 15

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On April 15, Olive Garden, is making its Indian debut with Gurugram’s vibrant culinary landscape. Part of Darden Restaurants, one of the world’s largest full-service restaurant company headquartered in Orlando, Florida, Olive Garden has been championing Italian-American classics since 1982. In India, the restaurant will be run by Gourmet Investments, the company that has introduced India to premium global restaurant brands including PizzaExpress, Chili’s American Grill & Bar, and P.F. Chang’s.

Ramit Bharti Mittal, executive chairman, Gourmet Investments, says that the more concrete conversations with Gourmet Investments and the Olive Garden team began around five years ago, pre-Covid, and have since evolved thoughtfully. “As one of the world’s most loved American Italian restaurant brands and part of the Darden Group, Olive Garden was a natural addition to Gourmet Investments’ portfolio of iconic global dining brands. We have plans to expand the chain across Delhi-NCR in phases,” he says.

With over 900 restaurants in more than 12 countries, including Canada, Brazil, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, Olive Garden’s foray into India points at the country’s post-pandemic shift towards casual-dining restaurants. “Olive Garden occupies a distinct space in the dining landscape as a casual dining restaurant rooted in decades of legacy, rather than a fast-food format. While India has several Italian offerings, Olive Garden is globally loved for its authentic American-Italian cuisine, from freshly prepared pastas and classic sauces to its iconic never-ending soup or salad and bread sticks. It is designed as a relaxed, sit-down dining destination that encourages shared meals and family gatherings, which resonates strongly with Indian diners,” Ramit explains.

Tucked into the urban fold of New Delhi’s bustling Aerocity, Olive Garden spans approximately 2,300 to 2,900 square feet and can



(Below) Ramit Bharti Mittal, executive chairman, Gourmet Investments; (left) Lasagne classico, salad and warm breadsticks at Olive Garden. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Italy meets America in Delhi



accommodate around 94 guests. The space has been designed by Incubis, a long-standing design partner for Gourmet Investments who also worked on other global brands such as PizzaExpress and P.F. Chang’s. Of the space’s aesthetics, Ramit opines, “The space incorporates key elements from Olive Garden’s global design language, drawing inspiration from its Tuscan roots. With sun-washed walls, rustic texture, warm lighting and cosy details, the restaurant evokes the charm of an Italian villa while remaining contemporary and inviting.”

The menu, though under wraps, will be dishing out its signature classics. “The menu stays true to Olive Garden’s American Italian heritage while being thoughtfully adapted to local preferences. Guests can look forward to iconic classics such as tiramisu, along

with a wide selection of vegetarian and non-vegetarian offerings. As with Olive Garden globally, every entrée is served with the brand’s signature never-ending soup or salad and warm breadsticks, reinforcing its focus on generosity and comfort,” says Ramit.

Before leaving, he shares with us the top three recommendations from the chef: Tour of Italy, a signature experience that brings together three of the brand’s most loved dishes on one plate, offering variety, indulgence and comfort in a single serving; Lasagne Classico, a timeless favourite featuring layers of pasta, rich sauce and cheese, slow-baked for a deeply satisfying, homestyle flavour; and chicken alfredo, one of their most iconic dishes, known for its creamy, indulgent Alfredo sauce paired with perfectly cooked pasta and tender chicken.

Olive Garden, will be launched at 4 Worldmark, Aerocity, New Delhi, on April 15; a meal for two will be priced between ₹2,000 and ₹2,500.



When Women Rise, The World Advances.

For decades, conversations around women have been framed around empowerment, inclusion and progress. While these conversations are necessary, they often begin with a flawed premise — that women are only now stepping into influence. In truth, women have always led. What has changed is that the world is finally recognising it. In boardrooms, women today are shaping strategy, driving governance and building enterprises that are redefining industries. As entrepreneurs, they are not merely launching businesses; they are building ecosystems that’s rooted in purpose, sustainability and community impact. Their leadership is intuitive yet data-driven, empathetic yet commercially sharp. In hospitality, I have witnessed firsthand how women influence not just markets, but mindsets. They travel independently, invest in experiences and prioritise wellness, culture and meaningful engagement. They are decisive consumers, thoughtful leaders and powerful economic drivers. But beyond economic impact lies something deeper: resilience. Indian women, whether in metros or smaller towns, navigate layered expectations with extraordinary strength. They are professionals without relinquishing identity, caregivers without surrendering ambition, and leaders without losing compassion. The next chapter is not about giving women a seat at the table. It is about recognising that many tables were built because of them. True progress will not be measured by symbolic representation, but by structural equity, equal opportunity, equal safety and equal respect. When women rise, organisations stabilise. When women lead, communities strengthen. When women are heard, nations advance. The narrative must move from celebration once a year to commitment every day. Women are not the future. They are the present force shaping it.

Sunil Kumar
Vice President & General Manager



Malayalam

A wild, wild ride for sci-fi lovers



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Krishand's latest offering, *Masthishka Maranam: A Frankenbiting of Simon's Memories*, is a sci-fi flick - 'retro-futuristic/cyber-punk' - that feels more real than fiction, set in the not-too-distant future, 2046.

The future that Krishand takes us to is dystopian and occasionally hilarious for the sheer absurdity of things. A Neo-Kochi with its flying cars, drones, cyborgs, climate change, memories on sale and, among other things, people whose lives are virtuality-dependent get painful memories surgically removed. Like Krishand's other works, this film is complex, loaded with satire and socio-political commentary.

Rajisha Vijayan is impressive as Frida Soman, the superstar who is the stuff of everybody's fantasies in the film. Performances are exaggerated because the story demands it. Frida is a hat doff to Mexican artist Frida Kahlo. The film's universe has been built with thought, a generous dose of intelligence, and wit.

The action begins with Bimal Raj (Niranj Maniyanpillai Raju), who, to grieve the loss of his young daughter, plays a memory 'empathy' game to stay connected with her.

While he dwells on the memory of his child, his wife has those surgically removed. As the film progresses, the virtual and the real meld. We are left wondering about reality, perception...the post-modern condition!

Krishand's stories are layered with meanings and suggestions, and each time you watch, a new layer unravels. It also delves into how artificial intelligence works or, on occasion, how it does not work, like when Bimal asks his virtual housekeeper to play sad, swag music.

Dystopia is never comfortable; the closeness to how things are today in the world we live in, *Masthishka Maranam*, is plausible, therefore discomfort-inducing. The experience game, how it is shared, what it leads to - the trial, the incongruities of the case when it gets to court, the mic-shoving media circus a 'celebrity' trial becomes how a woman's stardom is packaged and, how it is 'consumed'.

There is so much going on that one wishes for a walk-through of it, to understand the writer's process as someone who reads society much like a sociologist with a sense of humour.

The actors, all of whom deliver, include the Krishand regulars, besides Niranj, Jagdish, Sanju Sivaram, Sachin Joseph, Santhy Balachandran, Vishnu Agasthya, and Zhins Shan. Nandhu and Suresh Krishna also essay important roles. Divya Prabha, with her hair dyed blond in parts, is an absolute unhinged delight to watch!

To sum up, Krishand's latest offering is not for everybody. It is chaotic, funny, absurd and scary.

Masthishka Maranam is currently running in theatres



A masala comedy of gold standards

Radikaa Sarathkumar's film, produced by Sivakarthiskeyan, announces Sivakumar Murugesan as Tamil cinema's most assured new disruptor

Tamil

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There's a new filmmaker in the block, who, by all means, seems to be the recalibrating voice Tamil mainstream cinema needed.

Sivakumar Murugesan's debut *Thaai Kizhavi* is a film that feels like the perfection of an archetype many filmmakers have been toying with over the last few years - it's a rollicking, leave-you-in-splits comedy that surprises you every step of its way, has a pressing emotional core, fields for the right progressive register, and leaves you feeling thoroughly satisfied.

In the colourful world of *Thaai Kizhavi*, everything and anything seems spring-loaded to tickle you or sting you. There's a tattoo of Kamal Haasan's face on a man's chest that gets its share of respect; there's a wayward drunkard whose only job is to keep alight a lamp outside the Lord Karuppan temple; there's a loudspeaker that somehow knows which Kamal song to play when, just like the photo of a deceased elderly man whose expressions keep changing. At the centre of it all is Pavunuthaayi (Radikaa Sarathkumar is exceptional), the stronghold around which all of Karumathur pivots, her daughter Suruli (Raichal Rabecca) and her good-for-nothing husband, her three dimwit sons, and a 40-something most-eligible bachelor of the town. Hell, heaven, and Karumathur all move around these wonderfully written characters.

Interestingly, the person we first meet is the one who would perfectly bookend this ensemble-driven story - the walls of the houses in Karumathur feature the male and female heads of the family, all except that of Pennycuick (Munishkanth), who does everything he can to get married. Then we meet Pavunuthaayi, who is a beautiful contradiction of all-embracing love and iron-fisted authority. Her daughter Suruli, in contrast, gets a muted entrance in the big shadow her mother

Thaai Kizhavi

Director: Sivakumar Murugesan

Cast: Radikaa Sarathkumar, Aruldoss., Munishkanth, Bala Saravanan, Singampuli

Storyline: When their elderly mother falls sick, her wastrel sons wish for her to die so as to procure her properties, but everything goes for a toss when they realise that she has hidden 160 sovereigns of gold somewhere



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casts. Every day, when Pavunuthaayi finishes her prayers and steps out of her house, sirens go off in the heads of the townsmen, for they know what is to come - she would go on a merciless walk around the town, collecting interests on the money she has lent over the years. "Kaal mulachi nadandhu varum ayyanaar aruva iva," "Local don-u, Sungudi kattivandha Superman-u," go the lyrics of a song, as in this duality of Pavunuthaayi lies the film's honest core. She once vowed that even if she dies, she would walk to the graveyard all by herself and lie down. Whether it was the doing of the Yaman, whom she mocks, or the Karuppan, who Vesakutta (Aathadi Kumaran) asks to take Pavunuthaayi away, the elderly woman gets bedridden all of a sudden.

The news reaches Pavunuthaayi's sons, wastrels of each kind, who get elaborate introductions that leave you in splits. Vijayan (Aruldoss), an auto driver, is the kind who would squander Rs 50 in pursuit of a one-rupee coin. Uppiliyan (Singampuli), a Kamal Haasan fanatic, rents out music systems to functions; he plays only Kamal songs to the dismay of fans of Rajinikanth, Sathyaraj, Ramki, and Raj Kiran. Meanwhile, flower seller Selvam's (Bala Saravanan) garlands all look shriveled - Sivakumar's brilliance lies in how even Selvam's relationship with flowers goes on a full journey in the film. The three prodigal sons all return to Karumathur, not because they are worried about their mother, but because she had vowed that none of them would get any share of her properties, at least until her death. A fourth and loud entrance is made by Pavunuthaayi's son-in-law (Muthukumar), vowing to collect the remainder of the dowry owed to him.

Meanwhile, a stranger, wearing white and other markings of a rich man, shows up and informs the sons of a shocking detail about their mother - she had bought 160 sovereigns of gold from the man's gold shop in Madurai. Unable to source the place where she has hidden the gold, the three men now become affectionate sons who hope to cure their mother from the sickness. A hilarious story about the true wealth of life begins.

The strength of *Thaai Kizhavi* is how organically the pieces fall into place.

Sivakumar hardly misses a beat - even a casual subplot about Suruli's son's romance with a young woman is handled with care and purpose. Moments that make a crowd burst out in laughter are stacked in a short joke-per-second ratio, but Sivakumar is conscious that no joke is crass, and the right message comes through.

Similarly, the use of hit yesteryear tracks - which has become a trend thanks to the likes of Lokesh Kanagaraj - hits a peak in *Thaai Kizhavi*, as Sivakumar displays an enchanting knack to know which lesser-used song (mostly of Kamal) works organically and where. It isn't just about booming the song in the background; Sivakumar changes the staging, shot composition, and editing of the scenes to suit the track.

Sivakumar also seems to be a deft screenwriter who knows when to scale down and when to shift gears. The post-intermission lull, which has been plaguing many Tamil films, seems premeditated here, as Sivakumar lays the groundwork for what is certainly one of the most satisfying third acts in a mainstream social-comedy. *Thaai Kizhavi* bats for all the right things, and every dialogue uttered in the climax motivated the audience to hoot and whistle. "Even when they pray to men for creation, protection and destruction, they must pray to women for wealth and education," goes one of those goosebumps-inducing lines. Perhaps, the only niggle with writing is how one-note Pavunuthaayi's daughters-in-law (Muthulakshmi, Nirosha and Abinaya) become and seem undeserving of the role they play in the climax. Even that seems passable in this otherwise neat film.

This is the work of an all-new filmmaking voice that doesn't wish to be constricted to set patterns. Sivakumar Murugesan has loudly announced his entrance, and he has all the signs of a game-changer that Tamil mainstream cinema has desperately needed. With *Thaai Kizhavi*, Tamil cinema has finally managed to start firing its cylinders in 2026.

Thaai Kizhavi is currently in theatres

A perceptive take on the #MeToo discourse

Hindi

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These days, the Kashyaps seem keenly interested in stories that probe the steep personal toll exacted by success, ambition, and power. Even as Anurag Kashyap's *Bandar* gets a date in theatres, sister Anubhuti Kashyap observes the post-#MeToo landscape through a perceptive lens in this Netflix original. A cross between psychological drama and a taut thriller, *Accused* stars Konkona Sensharma as Dr. Geetika Sen, a celebrated queer surgeon, and Pratibha Ranta as her partner, Dr. Meera, who has travelled from a conservative Meerut to the accepting lap of London.

The plot centres on how Dr. Geetika's meticulously built life begins to collapse under anonymous allegations of sexual misconduct and predatory behavior at her workplace. The complaints spiral into an enquiry



led by a sanctimonious journalist (Mashhoor Amrohi). As suspicion spreads about the doctor's past and personality, it causes an upheaval in Geetika's and Meera's lives and in our minds. Eroding reputation, fractured trust, and the agonising ambiguity of perception versus truth amid online trolling and public judgment - the ripple effects suck you into the narrative.

The film's core premise about a female and queer doctor accused in a #MeToo-type sexual misconduct

case, is bold and fresh. It inverts the overwhelmingly male-perpetrator pattern seen in most such narratives. Anubhuti and writers Sima Agarwal and Yash Keswani avoid treating queerness as an issue or trope, instead presenting it as a grounded reality. When it comes to the conflict, they deliberately lean into ambiguity - refusing easy answers about guilt, innocence, perception, and reputation. The approach seamlessly intertwines the thriller genre with social commentary and

psychological character study.

By inverting the #MeToo tropes, perhaps, they want to tell the flag bearers of the movement how the misconduct could look like when the accused is a female and is in a position of power. The thought paves the way for a layered exploration of how certainty collapses when evidence is withheld or contradictory, when patriarchy still breeds in the office spaces, and when speed of institutional and social-media judgment is cruel.

At the same time, set in a world where women in positions of power are no longer an exception, the film takes a critical view of the remnants of the broken glass ceiling. As the enquiry progresses and Meera hires a private detective (Sukant Goel), broader questions about control and who is believed surface. It is a tightrope walk, and Anubhuti glides on.

Eschewing melodrama and overt physical intimacy, she generates a character-driven unease and sensitively captures the emotional toll on Geetika's intimate relationship with Meera when the line between

misconduct and cheating gets blurred. She has a knack for telling compelling stories in a hospital setting. Here, the London hospital setting provides a sterile backdrop that amplifies isolation.

Even when you realise that the inversion of central conceit is deliberate to make a point, the performances keep you riveted. As Geetika, Sensharma portrays someone who is controlling, abrasive, or even unlikable at times, yet she commands fascination. With those shift eyes, clenched jaws, and stiff

cheekbones, and even the way she holds the mobile phone, Sensharma brings the physicality and the ambition that the role demands, as well as the frustration of a successful woman in a world that continues to look for shortcuts in her journey to the top.

Proving to be a perfect foil, Pratibha adds emotional depth with a nuanced portrayal of fragility and quiet strength in a crumbling relationship. As a partner who wants to believe Geetika but is grappling with whispers of allegations and past affairs, Pratibha delivers yet another eye-catching performance after *Laaptaa Ladies* (2024). Her subtle shifts in expression, hesitant silences, and small gestures of withdrawal help you appreciate Meera's internal architecture.

The naturalism in their interactions - tenderness undercut by doubt, protective instincts clashing with self-preservation - keeps one hooked.

Accused

Director: Anubhuti Kashyap

Cast: Konkona Sensharma, Pratibha Ranta, Sukant Goel, Mashhoor Amrohi

Synopsis: When a celebrated queer doctor in London is accused of sexual misconduct, her life unravels.

Accused is currently streaming on Netflix.

Bridgerton

Episodes: 4

Creator: Chris Van Dusen

Starring: Adjoa Andoh, Julie Andrews, Nicola Coughlan, Ruth Gemmell, Claudia Jessie, Luke Newton, Golda Rosheuvel, Luke Thompson, Yerin Ha, Katie Leung

Storyline: A funeral, a will, two proposals, a marriage, a parting, a return, and a new Lady Wistledown



Queen Charlotte rules the screen

Streaming

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Part 1 of Season 4 of the alternate-history Regency romance, *Bridgerton*, ended with Benedict (Luke Thompson), the second Bridgerton son, asking the maid Sophie (Yerin Ha) to be his mistress. There were other side plots as well in the series based on Julia Quinn's Bridgerton novels. Queen Charlotte (Golda

Rosheuvel) refuses to let her friend Lady Danbury (Adjoa Andoh) go to visit her native land, out of fear of loneliness more than any imperial will. Penelope (Nicola Coughlan), who is married to Colin (Luke Newton), the third Bridgerton son, and also the author of the popular society newsletter, Lady Whistledown (Julie Andrews, voice), is finding it increasingly difficult to continue. The fact that she has moved from silent observer to a publicly acknowledged Lady Whistledown makes it difficult for Penelope to gather any scandalous tales of the Ton. Sophie, the illegitimate daughter of Lord Penwood, is shown the door by her stepmother, Lady Araminta Gun (Katie Leung). When Araminta moves in next door to Bridgerton House she is determined to find and arrest Sophie on trumped-up charges, life gets increasingly complicated. Violet (Ruth Gemmell), the Bridgerton matriarch, has a second chance at love with Marcus (Daniel Francis), Lady

Danbury's brother. Hyacinth (Florence Hunt), the eighth and youngest Bridgerton child is excited about her debut until a death makes her swear off romance and marriage. The lives of club owner Will (Martins Imhangbe) and his wife Alice (Emma Naomi) are thrown topsy-turvy when Alice is accepted as the Queen's lady-in-waiting. Most of the subplots are resolved with Araminta getting what is coming to her (though not to the extent preferred), Eloise growing up, which is seen in her gentle handling of Hyacinth and graciousness towards Cressida. The Queen letting Lady Danbury go, in the sweetest, wordless exchange, was one of the highlights of Part 2 of Season 4. Posy being the good and kind stepsister is rewarded and Sophie finally gets to know that her father did indeed love her. Violet's choice is charming but sad. The finale at the Queen's ball, which is also a farewell to Lady Danbury, sees everything resolved. Jonathan Bailey returns for a cameo as Anthony, the eldest

Bridgerton son, with his wife, Kate, (Simone Ashley) after their trip to India. While some things beggar belief, and the class question is not properly addressed, it is the Queen's uproarious laughter that one remembers from the season finale. The clothes while mainly good, feature some weird fabric choices as well as Kate's sari-like gown, which did not work at all. The excess of bows on Cressida's gowns is rather distracting. There have been some comments on the sub-plots distracting from the main pair, but Benedict and Sophie share enough chemistry to have us rooting for them. There are quite a few touching moments in the show but the one that brought a lump to the throat was Sophie arriving for her marriage on the arm of the footman Alfie (David Moorst) in the much debated post-credit sequence.

Bridgerton is currently streaming on Netflix

Snippets



Vijay Sethupathy's web series Kaattaan gets release date

Vijay Sethupathy's upcoming Tamil series, *Kaattaan* will be released on JioHotstar on March 27. Created by M. Manikandan, who has directed it with B.Ajith Kumar, the show's teaser was unveiled to make the announcement. The teaser opens with a man discovering a severed head. He calls the cops, who begin a manhunt. A quirky voice over of Vijay puts up a challenge to them to find the body. There are dark visuals of him walking around as a menacing music plays in background. The teaser ends with the visual of the severed head, which turns out to be that of Vijay wearing a broad smile. The series also stars Milind Soman, Sudev Nair, Vadivel Murugan, Risha Jacobs, VJ Paaru, Kalaivani Bhaskar, and Muthukumar in pivotal roles.



Nawazuddin Siddiqui joins Tumbbad 2

Actor Nawazuddin Siddiqui has joined Sohum Shah's *Tumbbad 2*, the latter announced through a social media post. The film is a sequel to the critically acclaimed 2018 period-horror drama which was helmed by Rahi Anil Barve and Anand Gandhi and produced by Sohum. *Tumbbad 2* was officially announced by Sohum in September 2024. The film will not be directed by Rahi, who is working on a trilogy of films, comprising *Tumbbad*, *Pahadpangira* and *Pakshitirtha*. Instead, it will be helmed by Aadesh Prasad, who served as the co-director, co-writer and co-producer on the original. Sohum Shah Films and Pen Studios produce the film. Meanwhile, Nawazuddin was recently seen in *Raat Akeli Hai: The Bansal Murders*.



Aspirants Season 3 gets premiere date

Streaming service Prime Video has announced the new season of its acclaimed show, *Aspirants*. Created and produced under the banner of The Viral Fever (TVF), the season 3 of the show is directed by Deepesh Sumitra Jagdish. It will premiere on Prime Video on March 13. The show stars Naveen Kasturia, Shivankit Singh Parihar, Abhilash Thapliyal, Sunny Hinduja, Namita Dubey, and Tengam Celine, with Jatin Goswami as the newest addition to the cast. The first season of the show streamed on the platform in 2021 and told the story of three friends preparing for the UPSC exams. It was followed by the second season in 2023.



A masterful anatomy of political fear

To anatomise fear as fiction is to recognise its very real mechanics in the places we actually live, and that uncomfortable truth is what elevates *The Secret Agent*

Portuguese

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The *Secret Agent* intended to feature a great white shark both on screen and off it – as flesh-and-blood predator that populates the headlines like an *idée fixe*, and as *Jaws* (*Tubarão* in its Brazilian incarnation) tearing through Recife's cinemas for the first time – because any film that keeps Spielberg's great communal fright carried by my preferred apex predator in active circulation has already anticipated my weaknesses. That personal bias *may* have tipped the film towards something generational for me even once it became clear that Kleber Mendonça Filho wasn't indulging trivia or nostalgia. With his Oscar-nominated follow-up to his 2023 Recife-set documentary, *Pictures of Ghosts*, the Brazilian auteur seems to fully grasp that cinema tutors its audiences where to deposit their fears, and once something as absurd as a shark becomes the popular container for civic anxiety, the real machinery of violence gains room to operate elsewhere with minimal scrutiny. Set in Recife in 1977, at the height of Carnival and deep into a regime that had learned how to disappear people quietly, the film follows Marcelo (played by a bravura Wagner Moura) a widowed university researcher traveling under a false name after crossing a federal official who attempted to privatise his publicly funded work. Unsurprisingly, the act of professional resistance soon turns into a death sentence administered through hired killers and obliging police. *The Secret Agent* is the most concentrated articulation yet of what Mendonça Filho has been circling throughout his career, that extends the spine of '60s-'70s Cinema Novo, and tells the same story of people fighting to keep their bearings while global capitalism, state power, and cultural vandalism close in from every side, with restless ingenuity. Moura is introduced through one of Mendonça Filho's most rigorously

The Secret Agent

Director: Kleber Mendonça Filho

Cast: Wagner Moura, Carlos Francisco, Tânia Maria, Robério Diógenes, Maria Fernanda Cândido, Gabriel Leone, Alice Carvalho, Hermila Guedes, Isabél Zuaa, and Udo Kier

Storyline: In 1977, Marcelo, a technology teacher, moves from São Paulo to Recife during Carnival to escape his violent past and start over. He finds the city full of chaos, and his neighbours begin to spy on him

designed openings, as Marcelo stops his striking, yellow Beetle at a rural gas station where a corpse lies decomposing under cardboard while the police ignore the body and focus on extorting him. The opener established a moral order under Brazil's erstwhile military dictatorship in which violence has been fully absorbed into administrative habit. From there, the narrative settles into Recife with patience, introducing a safe-house apartment complex overseen by Dona Sebastiana, played by a terrific Tânia Maria with weathered snark and a voice that carries decades of political fatigue. The space doubles as a temporary refuge for dissidents, migrants, queer runaways, and other endangered folk. Marcelo's personal stakes sharpen through his reunion with his young son Fernando, cared for by his late wife's parents, including a projectionist grandfather whose daily labour inside the real-life Cinema São Luiz links the film directly to *Pictures of Ghosts*'s explorations of Recife's movie palaces and grounds the thriller inside a broader meditation on cultural memory. Production-wise, the film is built with meticulous period specificity that never calls attention to itself as décor, as production designer Thales Junqueira fills the frame with manual typewriters, egg-shaped phone booths, crowded shelves, and heat-heavy interiors that communicate both era and class position, while costume designer Rita Azevedo dresses characters in a confrontational palette of yellows, blues, and greens that subtly echoes national symbolism without drifting into abstraction. The realism of the setting carries a sensory weight, as the sunny, sultry Brazilian summer is captured with a tactility that feels woozy and faintly nostalgic. The decision to shoot in anamorphic Panavision with cinematographer Evgenia Alexandrova gives the image a high-contrast density that favours lateral movement and deep backgrounds, allowing Mendonça Filho to stage power relations within a single frame rather than through montage that keeps the film grounded in observation even during moments of surreal intrusion. The political context emerges through operational details such as wiretapped conversations, opened telegrams, falsified

records, and the insouciance with which officials expect compliance, situating the dictatorship as a banal ecosystem of casual cruelties. Mendonça Filho's decision to cut intermittently to the present, where young researchers transcribe cassette tapes connected to Marcelo's case, reframes the narrative as an act of recovery, suggesting that history persists through material traces that require patience and care to interpret. What made *The Secret Agent* my favourite film of the year was the clarity in recognising how that same grammar of fear plays out in the here and now. The cadence of authoritarianism in erstwhile Recife feels disconcertingly familiar if you've been paying attention to how the social inoculation against dissent is handled in India today. If you've watched how the state's rolling use of laws to detain the likes of Umar Khalid or Sonam Wangchuk, the bureaucratic terror in *The Secret Agent* feels almost local in dialect. This isn't to conflate contexts simplistically, but there is a recognisable logic in the way power normalises surveillance and silence, whether through Brazil's unresolved reckoning with its dictatorship or India's contested transformation toward an exclusionary civic order; a nationalist fervour that has, in multiple arenas, restructured citizenship, culture, and collective memory into tools of control rather than sites of freedom. There is also a certain gall in observing this logic of normalisation, because what *The Secret Agent* does with dream-logic and genre pastiche is exactly what the immediate realities around us do in sober daylight by rebranding fear and coercion as "national security". The film advances a bracing thesis in which forgetting accrues material cost, and fascism sustains itself by laundering cultural amnesia into the language of stability and order. To anatomise fear as fiction is to recognise its very real mechanics in the places we actually live, and that uncomfortable truth is what elevates *The Secret Agent* above and beyond the year's more self-satisfied seriousness and leaves it the most urgent Best Picture nominee in the race this year.

The Secret Agent is currently running in theatres